

Fig. 2: Separate 2D and 3D view orientations

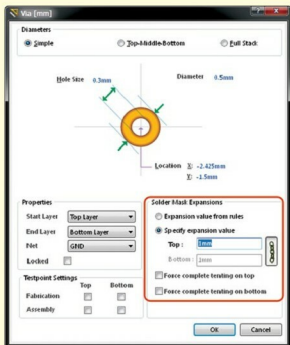


Fig. 3: Specifying the solder expansion for an individual pad/via through the via/pad properties dialog

Separate 2D and 3D view orientations. In previous versions of Altium Designer, on switching from 2D view to 3D, or from 3D to 2D, the region of focus remains the same. But these two views are completely separated in the latest version. Each view retains the orientation, zoom and layer configurations of its previous display.

We can also have an in-depth examination of design-type features by clicking **ctrl + ctrl**.

IDX MCAD integration support. Electronic designs, nowadays, involve more and more electrical and mechanical components. This calls

for an increased collaboration between the electrical and mechanical computer-aided design (ECAD and MCAD) domains. Unfortunately, engineers working on these domains use different design tools, and communication between them is not so easy.

As a solution, a collaborative standard known as incremental design exchange (IDX) format has been introduced. This standard enables the two to graphically communicate ideas and proposals for change, without leaving their trusty working environments. Support for this standard of collaboration between ECAD and MCAD domains is available in Altium Designer 15. It will help in easy synchronisation of the enclosure model, board shape and component placement for the best mechanical fit.

What to expect

Reviews from various forums suggest that users are very satisfied with this product. A blogger feels that Altium Designer is a good product for a good price. Initially, he was suspicious about the online services given by the company. He mentioned that, if the user becomes dependent, the company could charge him more. But Altium

is altogether different, concludes the blogger from his experience.

Another user feels, "The graphical interface of this tool is the first thing that I noticed. The software looks new and fresh as compared to other CAD tools. The library consists of one single file. All CAD tools should follow this model. It makes transferring and sharing your library a breeze. Copying components from one library to the next is a simple copy-and-paste function. In general, the library manager could not be much better. The wizard has many component types to choose from and is very easy to use. All objects can be modified using the property option, which gives the designer lots of flexibility. The measure function is very good as well and provides all necessary information (centre to centre, edge to edge)."

Some users of earlier versions had suggested that the designer should retain the orientation, zoom and layer configurations of its previous display, on switching to and from 2D and 3D displays. This issue has been resolved in the latest version of Designer. The user forgets not to comment on the exceptional quality of the 3D display that Altium Designer offers.

Overall, users are very happy with the experience that Altium Designer can offer. Altium Designer 15 has worked on problematic areas of an electronic design engineer and improvised features, such as giving separate 2D and 3D view orientations. With new features, like xSignals and solder mask-expansion enhancements, Altium has prepared itself to meet the challenges offered by the latest developments of the electronics design industry.

Altium Designer is a one-stop electronic design environment that can help you save time and money. The trial version of the latest in this software series, Altium Designer 15, is included in this month's issue of EFY Plus. ●

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